

Current Status of Meaningful Credentials for Students With Intellectual Disabilities Attending TPSID Model Demonstration Programs

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In 2010, the Office of Postsecondary Education awarded grants to 27 institutions of higher education (IHEs) to create or expand access to higher education for students with intellectual disabilities in 23 states. These model demonstration projects, known as Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities (TPSIDs), were asked to create meaningful credentials for students who completed their programs.

No additional guidance was provided about the essential components of the “meaningful credential,” and it was up to each IHE to determine the course of study requirements necessary to earn the credential. While some TPSID grantees had established programs, others were creating new programming. Therefore, there is significant variability in the rate of credential development, as well as the composition of the established credentials across the TPSID grantees.

In Year Three of the five-year program, most TPSID grantees (38 out of 44) offered some type of credential (Figure 1). Credentials were certificates or degrees available either to students in the TPSID only, or to all students. Credentials were granted by the IHE, by the TPSID program, or by a partnering local education agency (LEA).

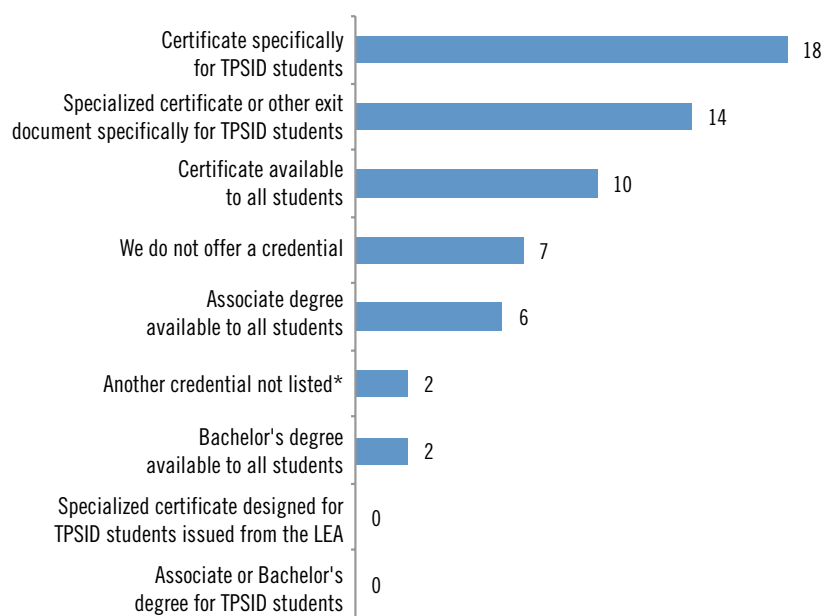
The most common credentials available were certificates, with the largest number being certificates available to students in the TPSID only but granted by the IHE. It was more common for TPSIDs to offer specialized credentials to their students with intellectual disabilities than to offer credentials available to all college students.

A very small number of IHEs offered a path toward an associate and bachelor's degree. Four-year IHEs were more likely to offer a specialized certificate granted by the TPSID (41% vs. 13%). A majority of students attending TPSIDs (71%) were seeking a credential in 2012–2013. Another 4% were not seeking the available credential, and 23% were enrolled in programs not offering a credential.

Students who were in their second or third year were slightly more likely to be seeking a credential than students

in their first year (76% vs. 68%). Dually enrolled students were less likely to be seeking a credential from the college (57% vs. 76%), but this is to be expected as they are still high school students and would be receiving their culminating documentation from their LEA.

Figure 1. Credentials available to students attending TPSIDs, 2012–2013 (N=44 campuses)



* “Career Readiness Credential (WorkKeys)” and “specialized certificate available to both TPSID and non-TPSID students.”

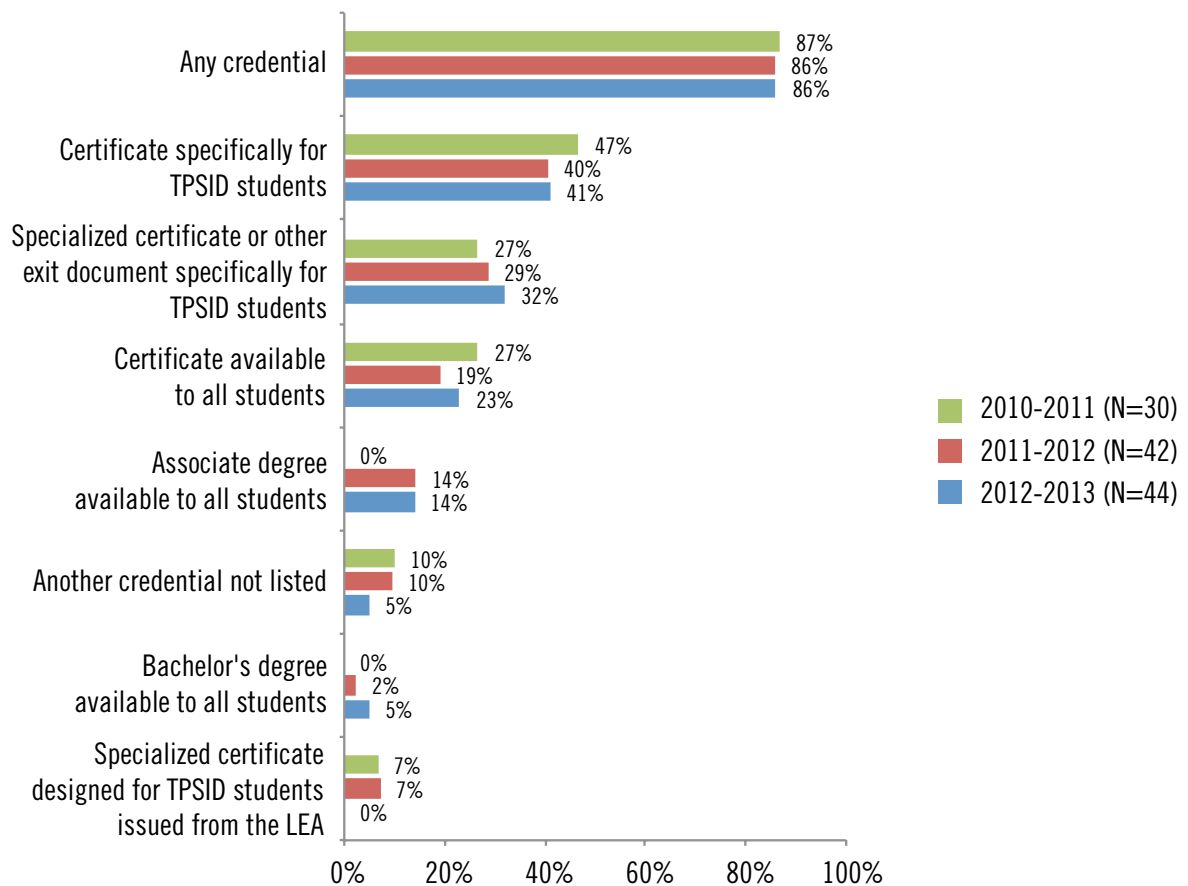
Three years of data reflects an increase in the percentage of course enrollments that were for some type of credit (Figure 2). This could be a standard IHE credit that could be used towards a certificate or degree, or a credit that could only be used towards a TPSID credential. Sixty-one percent of enrollments in Year One awarded some type of course credit, while 81% of enrollments were for credit in Year Three. TPSIDs should continue to pursue credit-bearing course opportunities for their students to ensure they are on a path to earning a credential that will be meaningful in the job market.

There has been little variation in the types of credentials available to students attending a TPSID over the three years

of the project. The proportion of TPSIDs offering a credential has been steady, ranging from 86% to 87%. While most students do have access to some sort of credential, Figure 2 shows there are still some sites that do not award any sort of credential to their students. As in Years One and Two, credentials designed specifically for students attending the TPSID are the most common.

Figure 2. Trends in credentials available to students, 2010–2013

(N=Number of programs serving students in given program year)



While the TPSID National Coordinating Center has no authority over the IHEs that are implementing the TPSID projects, it is charged with providing technical assistance to all of the grantees. Therefore, the coordinating center has conducted trainings and developed resources to assist the TPSID projects in development and refinement of their credentials. These tools provide program directors with guidance regarding credential development, including aligning the credential process with accreditation and communicating information about the credential to colleagues, families, students, and employers.

The process for developing a credential that is meaningful both within and outside of the IHE takes significant resources and time. As future programs continue to establish credentials, it is imperative that they take into account the existing institutional practices and processes for credential approval, and the extensive time necessary for credentials to be reviewed and approved by the IHE.



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